laymen who have studied all of the above are said to have ‘mastered grammatical science’ and hence qualify to be ‘well-informed’.

After outlining the grammatical sciences curriculum, Yijing names more authors whose works monks had to study.[15] As the brightest monks progress through their study, he adds, they aspire not only to master the topic but to advance it. For instance, ‘when they have understood the arguments of *Hetuvidya* (logic), they aspire to be like Gina (the great reformer of logic) . . . When they discourse on the “non-existence” they cleverly imitate Nagarjuna’, and so on.

What the monks studied at Nalanda included most flavours of Buddhism: two schools of Mahayana (Madhyamaka and Yogacara), eighteen schools of Theravada and later, during Pala times, Vajrayana, a Tantra-inflected form of Mahayana that lives on in Tibet. Though united by their goal of achieving liberation, or moksha, ‘the Tripitakas of various sects differ from one another’, writes Yijing, but they also had ‘small points of difference such as where the skirt of the lower garments is cut straight in one, and irregular in another, and the folds of the upper robe are, in size, narrow in one and wide in another’. Some student monks went much farther than their peers and acquired commensurate fame and respect as Buddhist masters.

The Stars of Nalanda

Nalanda produced and advanced impressive new ideas and secular knowledge. The Buddha had himself upheld the value of scepticism and strongly advocated a rigorous testing of views to one’s own satisfaction, rather than accepting them on authority. Nalanda became a scholastic institution par excellence, where philosophical ideas were deftly scrutinized, debated, refined, classified, recorded and taught. It was certainly a *universitas magistrorum et scholarium* (community of teachers and scholars, the Latin phrase from which the term ‘university’ is derived), though it was also different from what we understand as a university today. After all, it did not admit laymen, but only Buddhist monks who potentially came to stay for life, rather than graduate with degrees and return to public life (though they could return to the laity at any time, as many did after gaining an education; or go to another monastery; or strike out on their own